

DRAWING TO AN END

Thursday, 23 April 2026, 12:45 - 2:15 PM EST.

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DRAWING begins when a hand pulls a point across a surface and leaves a trace. In that act, an pulled by the artist is made visible to others. Long before painting, perspective, or photography, drawing was a way of fixing images in material form.

The earliest drawings were incisions and scratches on stone. An engraved plaquette from Palaeolithic France, dating to about 11,000 BCE, depicts part of a horse with a long tail. Only about 10 cm wide and 3 cm thick, this small object was portable, meant to be held, carried, shown, and seen. Even at this tiny scale, drawing served its enduring function in the history of art: to make something absent present through a mark.

At the opposite extreme of scale, the Nazca lines in the Peruvian desert are among the largest ancient drawings: more than 700 images of geometric forms, plants, and animals. Made between 500 BCE and 500 CE by scratching into the desert surface, some stretch more than 300 meters across. These drawings could not be fully seen by the people who made them. They required planning, measurement, and a conception of form that exceeded ordinary human sight from the ground.

Now the Nazca lines can be seen from the air, by airplane or drone camera. Their visibility depends on a vantage that their makers did not have. These images are shaped not only by what they depict but by the position from which they are meant to be seen. The Nazca lines are drawings for an imagined viewer. An image is often a constructed point of view.

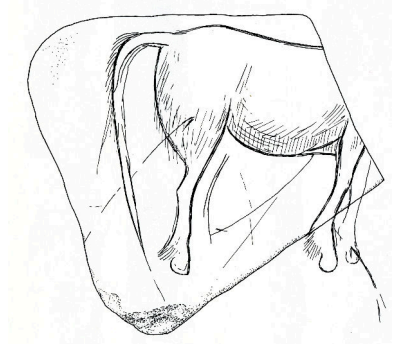


Figure 228: *Engraved horse*, [British Museum](#)

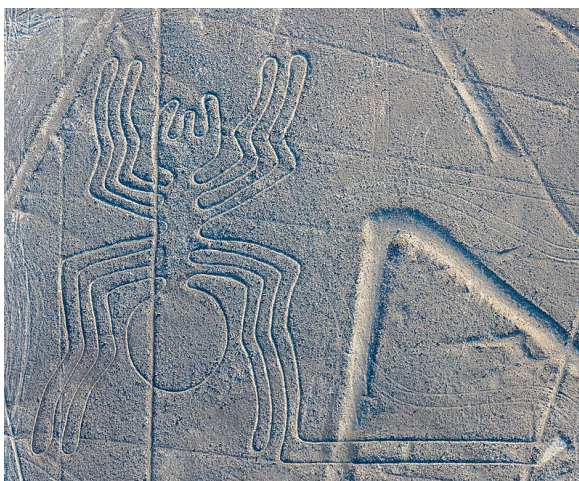


Figure 229: *The Spider*, one of the Nazca geoglyphs in southern Peru. Its full form becomes legible only from above, making it a striking example of a drawing whose intended viewpoint lies beyond ordinary human sight. [Wikipedia](#)

THE INVENTION OF PARCHMENT AND PAPER gave artists and readers portable surfaces on which to write, sketch, plan, and preserve images. At first these materials were scarce and costly. They were reserved for sacred texts and devotional books, where words could be “illuminated” by drawings and ornament. In such manuscripts, images did more than decorate the page. They guided attention, shaped understanding, and helped make the invisible visible.

The printing press transformed this world. After Gutenberg’s invention was reported in 1439, texts could be reproduced with movable type, and images with carved woodblocks or engraved metal plates. Print made paper more abundant and less expensive. What had once been precious became practical: a surface for experiment, study, and circulation.

When paper became cheap and plentiful, images could travel more easily, and so could ways of seeing. Artists could draw to think, revise, compare, and invent. Printed images could be copied, collected, and shared across long distances. In this sense, paper and print were not neutral media. They were technologies that trained artists and spread visual ideas, much as optical devices have done throughout art history.

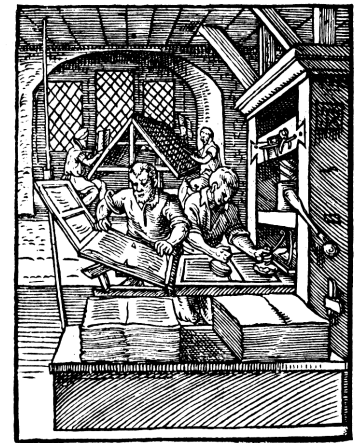


Figure 230: Woodcut showing a printer at left removing a page from the press while another at right inks the type-block. With such labor, a press shop could produce thousands of pages in a day.

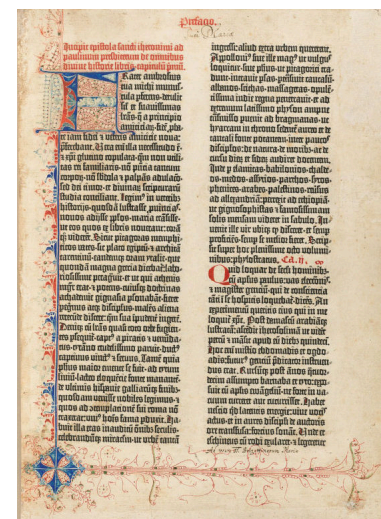


Figure 231: Page from Harvard’s copy of the Gutenberg Bible, printed on paper, one of 23 complete surviving copies. It is on display in the Harry Elkins Widener Memorial Rooms.

Figure 232: *The Utrecht Psalter*, made in the ninth century, is a celebrated manuscript whose lively pen drawings accompany the psalms and other sacred texts. It shows how, long before print, drawing on the page could animate words and direct the reader’s imagination. [Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Utrecht_Psalter)

WHEN PAPER BECAME PLENTIFUL, it became one of the most important instruments of artistic thought. Paper changed how artists worked, how ideas developed, and how visual knowledge could be tested, revised, and shared. With cheap and abundant paper, Renaissance artists could practice repeatedly, correct mistakes, and refine difficult problems before committing them to panel, wall, or canvas.

That change was crucial to the development of Renaissance realism. A convincing image did not emerge all at once in paint. It was often prepared through many acts of drawing, in which artists learned to analyze form, organize space, and coordinate hand with eye. Drawing was not just preliminary to other forms of art. It brought new discipline to visual representation.

PAOLO UCCELLO (1397–1475) used paper to work through one of the great problems of the Renaissance: linear perspective. Vasari describes him in the *Lives of the Most Excellent Painters, Sculptors, and Architects* as a solitary and single-minded man:

gifted with a sophisticated mind, he enjoyed investigating complex mechanisms and the strange products of the art of perspective.

That obsession is visible in his carefully constructed drawing of a chalice. The object matters less here than the act of projection itself. Uccello is not simply drawing a cup; he is studying how a three-dimensional thing can be translated onto a flat surface according to rule. In that sense, drawing becomes a laboratory for perspective, a place where vision is analyzed and space is made thinkable.

Like many such drawings, however, Uccello's studies were regarded as preparatory and expendable. They were working documents, not autonomous works of art, and most have been lost. Many important inventions first existed as disposable experiments.

THE NOTEBOOK was one of Leonardo da Vinci's most powerful habits of mind. About 6,000 sheets survive, perhaps only a fifth of what he originally produced. On these pages he developed compositions for paintings such as the *Last Supper*, but he also pursued questions far beyond painting: the motion of water, the structure of plants, the mechanics of flight, the anatomy of the body.

The notebook made visible the full range of Leonardo's curiosity. On paper, observation, speculation, and invention could coexist. He used every available drawing tool—pen and ink, metalpoint, charcoal, chalk—because drawing for him was not tied to a single medium or purpose. It was a general approach towards understanding the world.

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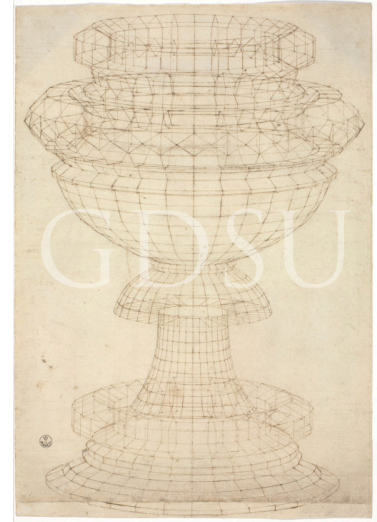


Figure 233: *Studio prospettico di calice*, 1450–70, Paolo Uccello. [Uffizi](#)



Figure 234: *Studies for The Adoration of the Magi and The Last Supper* in brown ink with quill pen and leadpoint, Leonardo da Vinci, [Louvre](#)

Throughout history, artists have searched for methods that make vision more exact, more intelligible, or more powerful: perspective constructions, optical devices, anatomical studies, systems of measurement. Leonardo's sheets show drawing at the center of this enterprise. To draw was to investigate: to study how things appear, how they are structured, and how they might be transformed into images.



Figure 235: *A deluge*, 1517–18, black chalk, pen and ink, and wash, Leonardo da Vinci. In late works like this, drawing becomes not just preparatory design but a way of imagining forces—water, motion, catastrophe—that exceed immediate sight. [Royal Collection Trust](#)

MICHELANGELO BUONARROTI (1475–1564) began even his greatest paintings with drawings, many of which he later destroyed. Vasari writes

to the end that no one might see the labours endured by him and his methods of trying his genius, and that he might not appear less than perfect.

About 600 sheets survive, including studies for the Sistine Chapel. These drawings reveal something essential that finished works often conceal: realism is rarely immediate. It is achieved through repeated trial, correction, and invention. Before Michelangelo painted Adam on the ceiling, he worked through the figure on paper, testing the body until he found the pose he wanted.

For Adam, Michelangelo drew on an extraordinary knowledge of human anatomy, gained in part from studying flayed corpses. Yet the resulting figure is not simply a copy of nature. Adam's pose is convincing, but it is also invented: no living human could bend the torso in quite this way. Michelangelo used drawing not merely to record what the eye sees, but to imagine a body more powerful, expressive, and monumental than any ordinary body in life.

Artists often seek not just to imitate appearances, but to understand and re-make them through design. Michelangelo's drawings show that a persuasive image may depend on close study of nature, even as it departs from nature in the service of artistic truth.

These studies were then enlarged on cartoons and transferred to the ceiling before Michelangelo began to paint. Drawing thus served as the crucial intermediary between idea and image, between the searching work of the hand and the seeming inevitability of the finished fresco.

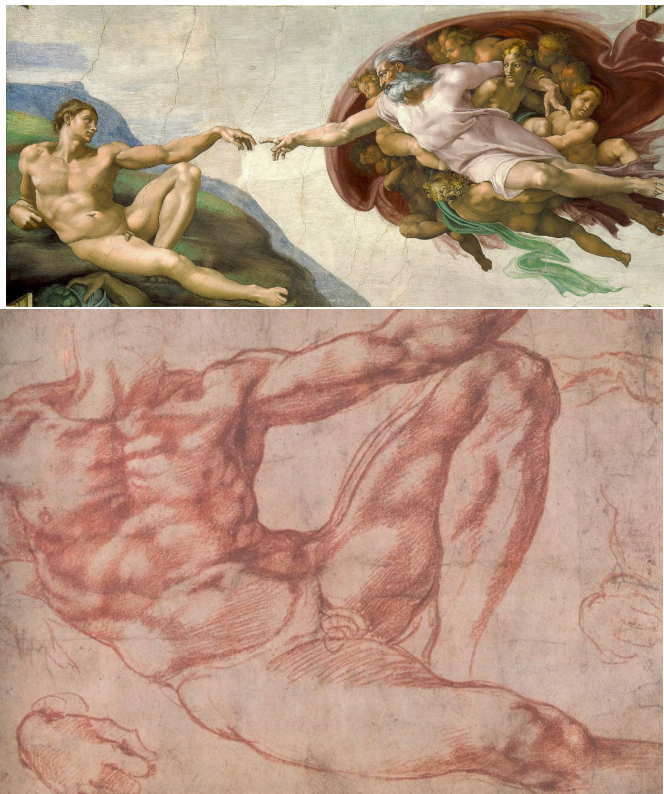


Figure 236: *The Creation of Adam*, Sistine Chapel ceiling, 1512, alongside a red chalk study by Michelangelo. The comparison shows how drawing functioned as a site of anatomical study, formal invention, and preparation for one of the most famous painted figures in Western art.

SIR PETER PAUL RUBENS (1577–1640) also used drawing to build images that were not direct transcriptions of a single view. His grand landscapes were assembled from visual ideas gathered on paper as he moved through the Flemish countryside. Drawing allowed him to observe the world closely, store its effects in memory, and later recombine them into painted scenes of remarkable richness and conviction.

His panel painting of *Het Steen*, the manor where he lived, invents an autumn morning rather than recording one particular instant. Rubens was not simply copying what lay before his eyes. He was studying visual phenomena and then reworking them into an image that feels true. The painting draws on sketches and notes in which he recorded fleeting effects such as light on water, atmosphere, and reflection.

In one drawing, Rubens writes down an optical observation that he wanted to preserve:

The reflection of the trees in the water is browner and more perfect in the water than the trees themselves.

That sentence is revealing. It shows Rubens attending not just to objects, but to appearances: to the way light alters color, how reflection transforms form, and how vision itself can produce effects more beautiful or more intense than the thing reflected. Rubens's drawings therefore occupy a middle ground between observation and invention. They are records of seen effects, but also tools for constructing a world on canvas. In them, drawing becomes a way of thinking about optics.



Figure 237: *An Autumn Landscape with a View of Het Steen in the Early Morning*, 1636, Peter Paul Rubens. Rather than recording a single observed moment, the painting synthesizes remembered and studied effects of landscape, weather, and light into an image that feels both natural and composed.

[National Gallery](#)



Figure 238: *Trees Reflected in Water at Sunset*, 1635–38, Peter Paul Rubens, pen and brown ink. In drawings like this, Rubens isolates an optical effect—reflection on water—and studies it as something worth remembering in its own right. [British Museum](#)

DRAWING TOOLS IMPROVED OVER TIME. Renaissance tools such as ink and metalpoint were exacting and unforgiving: once a line was made, it could rarely be undone. Chalk and charcoal allowed greater softness, but they smudged easily. With the widespread use of the graphite pencil in the late eighteenth century, artists gained a tool of unusual flexibility and precision. Its point could be sharpened to great fineness; with changes in pressure and stroke, it could produce faint lines, dark accents, subtle textures, and gradual shading.

The pencil changed not only how artists drew, but what a drawing could be. It made drawing more responsive to observation and revision, and it helped transform works on paper into finished artworks in their own right rather than merely preparatory steps toward painting or printmaking. In that sense, a new tool also brought with it a new conception of seeing: more provisional, more empirical, and more attentive to subtle effects.

JOHN CONSTABLE is best known for his oil landscapes, but his graphite drawings are among the clearest expressions of his artistic method. His exquisitely detailed study of elm trees is not simply a sketch for something else; it is a fully realized work of art. In other works on paper, he combined graphite with watercolor, using each medium to register a different aspect of what he saw.

Constable's attitude toward landscape, across all these media, is captured in his famous remark:

Painting is a science, and should be pursued as an inquiry into the laws of nature. Why, then, may not landscape painting be considered as a branch of natural philosophy, of which pictures are but the experiments?

Constable treats image-making not as fantasy or mere decoration, but as investigation. His drawings and paintings test how clouds, trees, water, and atmosphere appear under changing conditions. Constable suggests that making images can be a form of disciplined looking, a way of studying the visible world through repeated acts of attention.

In Constable's hands, drawing becomes both record and experiment. It preserves what he saw, but it also probes nature analytically, asking how visual truth might be built on paper through line, tone, and touch.

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Figure 239: *A Mill Near Colchester*, 1833, John Constable. Watercolor over traces of graphite, with scratching out and a touch of pen and brown ink on the horizon; evidence of squaring for transfer in graphite, with a color wash test on the verso. [Metropolitan Museum](#)

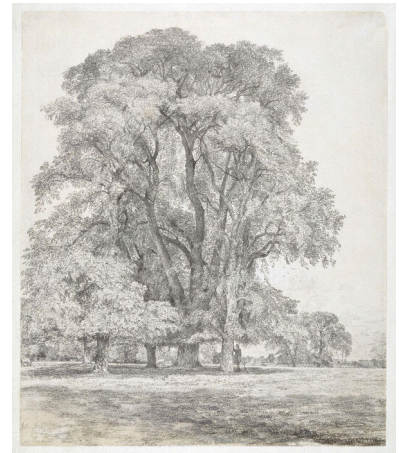


Figure 240: *Elm Trees in Old Hall Park, East Bergholt*, 1817, John Constable, graphite on paper. The drawing shows how graphite could sustain a patient, exact study of natural form while also standing as a finished work in its own right. [Victoria and Albert Museum](#)



Figure 241: *A Landscape with a Church Tower and a House*, 1809, John Constable, graphite on cream antique laid paper. [Harvard Art Museums](#)

IN NORTHERN EUROPE, Albrecht Dürer (1471–1528) was one of the heirs to the Northern tradition of exacting visual description (Fig. 242). From an early age, he displayed an extraordinary control of line and a patient attention to surface. In works such as the *Young Hare* (Fig. 244), that attention becomes almost forensic. The watercolor renders fur in different directions, mottled shifts of tone, and the wet glint of the eye with a precision that feels nearly scientific.

Was this image painted from prolonged study of a living animal, or from the still body of a dead one? We do not know. What matters is the kind of looking the image implies. Like the tiny dog in Van Eyck's *Arnolfini Portrait*, the hare invites us to imagine an artist attending to the world at the level of minute particulars. Here drawing and painting reveal seeing as a form of inquiry.

Raphael, also a gifted draughtsman, exchanged letters and images with Dürer. Yet the two artists represent slightly different possibilities in the history of art. Raphael made his career primarily through painting. Dürer, shrewdly attuned to the power of paper, devoted himself not only to drawing but also to engraving and woodcut printing. He understood earlier than most artists that the future of images would depend not just on their making, but on their reproduction and circulation.

Dürer recognized the significance of new systems of dissemination: print and long-distance communication. The printing press made it possible for images to be multiplied and widely distributed; improved postal networks allowed artistic ideas to travel with unprecedented speed. Together these developments transformed the conditions of artistic fame. Dürer's *Apocalypse* was printed and seen throughout Europe (Fig. 246), so that when he traveled, his reputation often arrived before he did.

Ways of seeing do not spread only through masterpieces hanging in one place. They spread through portable media, reproducible images, diagrams, prints, and books. Dürer stands at the center of that transformation. He was not only a master of observation, but also one of the first artists to grasp that paper could carry knowledge and fame across distances.



Figure 242: *Self-Portrait*, 1484, Albrecht Dürer, silverpoint. Made when the artist was about twelve or thirteen, it is his earliest known surviving drawing and one of the earliest self-portraits in European art. [Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Albrecht_Dürer).



Figure 243: Probably a self-portrait of Raphael as a teenager.



Figure 244: *Young Hare*, 1502, Albrecht Dürer, watercolor and gouache on paper. The work has long been admired for its extraordinary descriptive precision, which makes close looking itself seem like a form of disciplined study. [Wikipedia](#).

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DÜRER was among the first artists to understand the value of a visual trademark. His monogram, the *D* set beneath the *A*, identified his work at a glance and asserted his authorship wherever the image traveled. In a world of reproducible prints, such a mark mattered. It helped secure credit, discouraged imitation, and made the artist's name portable along with the image itself.

This development was historically significant. In earlier periods, artists often remained subordinate to workshops, patrons, or traditions larger than themselves. But print altered that balance. Once an image could be multiplied and dispersed widely, the question of who made it became more urgent. Dürer's monogram therefore does more than sign a work. It marks a new conception of the artist as an individual maker whose style, invention, and intellectual property could circulate across Europe.

Images are shaped not only by what they show, but how they are made visible, transmitted, and recognized. Dürer's monogram belongs to that history. It is a tiny device, but it links drawing, print, authorship, and the public life of images.



Figure 245: Dürer's monogram, the intertwined *A* and *D* that became one of the earliest and most recognizable artistic signatures in Europe.



Figure 246: The third woodcut from Dürer's *Apocalypse*, from the series published in 1498. The print illustrates Revelation 6:1–8, the opening of the first four seals and the appearance of the Four Horsemen. Reproduced in large numbers and widely distributed, images like this helped establish Dürer's international reputation and showed how print could carry powerful visual ideas far beyond their place of origin. [Metropolitan Museum of Art](#)

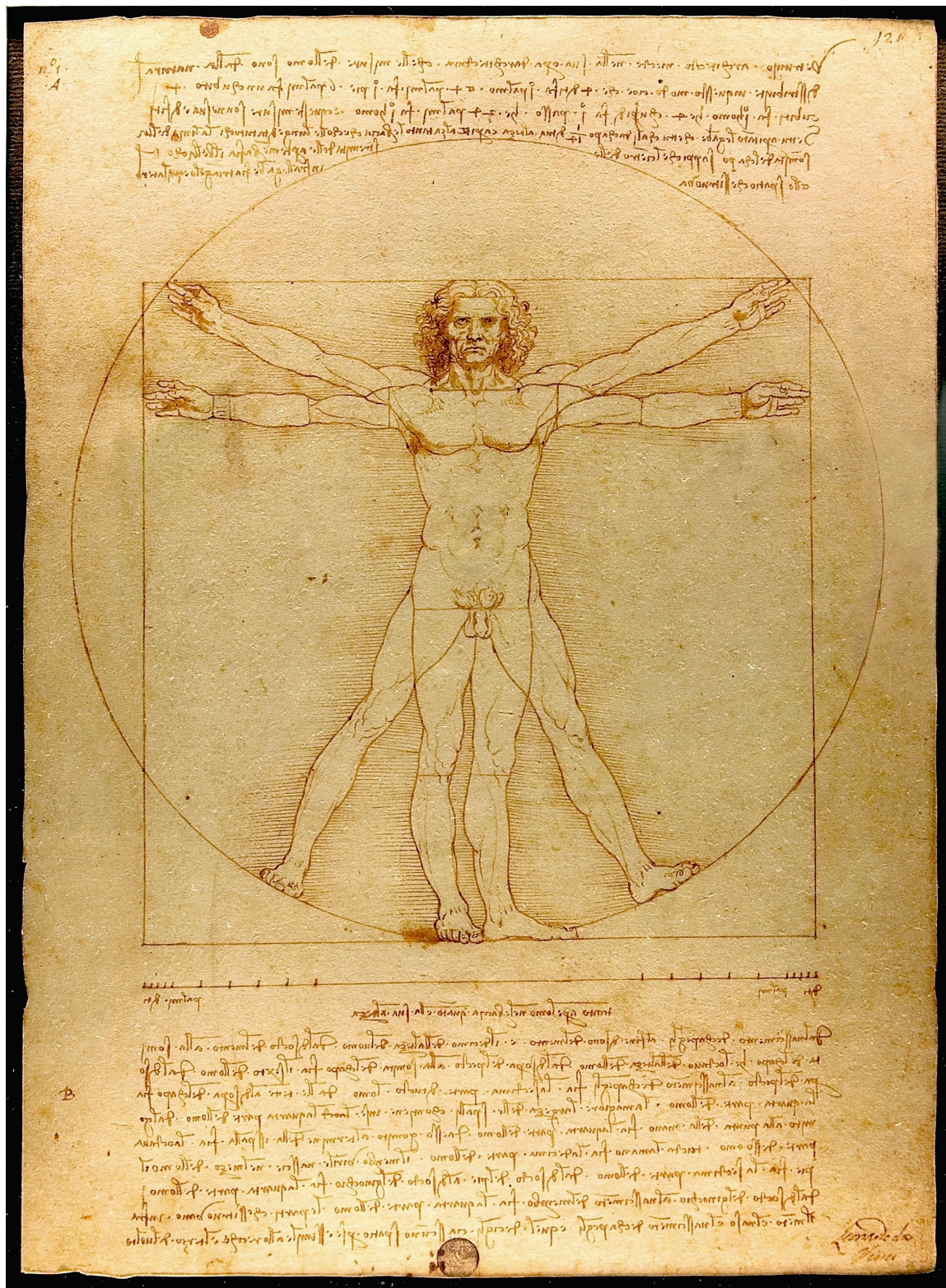


Figure 249: Leonardo's *Vitruvian Man*, a study of ideal bodily proportion grounded in measurement, classical theory, and geometrical order. Like Dürer's treatises, it reflects the Renaissance ambition to relate the human body to a rational structure of space and number.

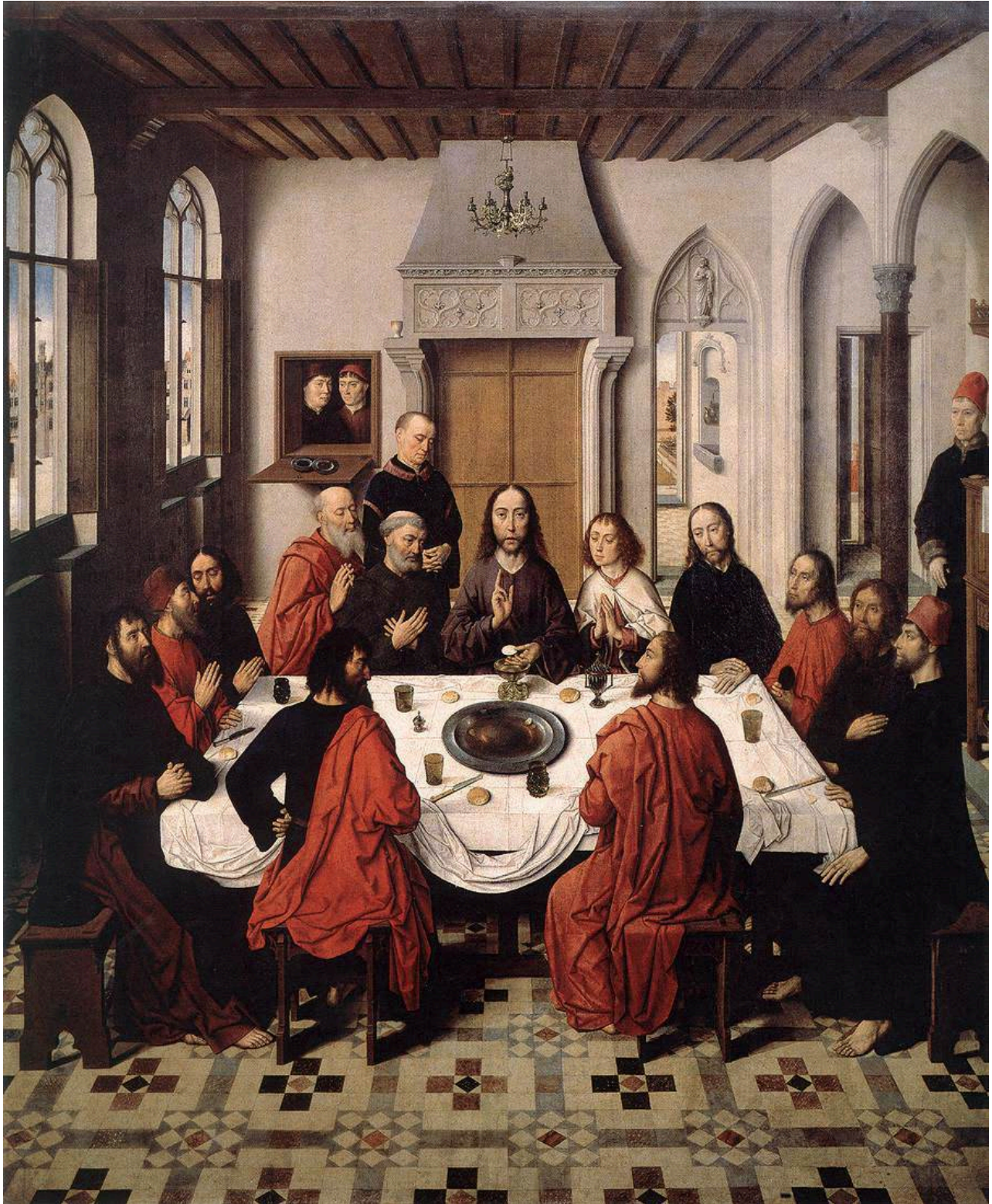


Figure 250: *Altarpiece of the Holy Sacrament* by Dieric Bouts [Link to Wikipedia](#)

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WHEN DÜRER made his woodcut of *The Presentation of Christ in the Temple* in 1505, he already possessed an intuitive grasp of perspective. Like Dieric Bouts, he filled the composition with receding floors, slanting architectural members, and directional lines that suggest depth. But the system is not yet fully coherent. The orthogonals do not align consistently, and the image lacks a stable central vanishing point. The ambition is unmistakable, but something is still unresolved.

Dürer wanted more than an approximate effect. He wanted to understand the theory behind perspective so that space could be constructed with the same rigor that Italian artists had begun to achieve. In 1506, he traveled to Italy to learn that theory at its source. Writing back to Nuremberg from Venice on 13 October 1506, he explained:

I shall be finished here in ten more days, then I shall ride to Bologna where someone is willing to teach me the secrets of perspective. I intend to stay there for about eight days and then return to Venice.

Ways of seeing are not simply discovered in isolation, but learned, transmitted, and refined across places, media, and generations. Perspective was not just a Florentine invention; it became a portable body of knowledge, carried by artists, drawings, prints, and treatises from one part of Europe to another.

DÜRER'S LATER WORK shows what that knowledge made possible. In his engraving of *St. Jerome* of 1514, interior space is organized with far greater confidence and clarity, structured around a coherent vanishing point (Fig. 252). What had earlier been an ambitious but unstable approximation becomes, a decade later, a disciplined construction of pictorial space.



Figure 251: *The Presentation of Christ in the Temple*, 1505, Albrecht Dürer. This early woodcut shows Dürer experimenting with perspectival recession before he had fully mastered the geometrical system he later sought in Italy. [Victoria and Albert Museum](#)



Figure 252: *St. Jerome* by Dürer, 1513.
An engraving of Saint Jerome, translator of the Bible into Latin and exemplar of Christian scholar. [Link to Metropolitan Museum of Art](#)

DÜRER TRAVELED THROUGHOUT EUROPE, and wherever he went, he carried paper. Paper made observation portable. It allowed the artist to record what he saw, preserve visual ideas, and bring them home for later use. In Italy, Dürer purchased blue paper, or *carta azzura*, made in Venice. On this colored ground, he explored a different way of creating three-dimensional form: not through geometry, but through tonal modeling.

His *Praying Hands* of 1508, made as a study for an altarpiece, builds volume through hatching, ink, and white highlights laid over the medium-toned blue surface. The drawing is a reminder that the convincing appearance of form could be achieved by more than one method. Artists seek reliable ways to render the visible world—through perspective, measurement, optics, and anatomical study. Here Dürer shows how to make the hand become solid with light and shadow that are carefully felt.

IN 1520, DÜRER TRAVELED TO ANTWERP, one of the busiest ports in Europe and a major center of Northern art and commerce. By then, his fame preceded him. Within days of his arrival, the painters' guild held a banquet in his honor. A working artist was being treated with a distinction once reserved mainly for nobles and princes.

And as I was conducted to the table the company rose to their feet and lined the way, as if some great lord were entering.

The growing wealth of the Netherlands, fueled by trade and an expanding luxury market, helped create new publics for images and new prestige for those who made them. Dürer's hosts were honoring not only a skilled draughtsman, but also a pioneer of print: an artist whose works on paper could be collected, circulated, and admired far from their place of origin.



Figure 253: *Praying Hands*, 1508, Albrecht Dürer. Drawn on blue paper with ink and white heightening, the study shows how modeling and tonal contrast could create a vivid sense of volume without relying on linear perspective alone. [Wikipedia](#)



Figure 254: *Tuft of Cowslips*, 1526, Albrecht Dürer. In this late work, close observation and artistic economy come together in a study of humble plant life rendered with extraordinary clarity and grace. [National Gallery of Art](#)

In Antwerp, Dürer sketched the harbor and dated the drawing 1520, suggesting that he regarded it as complete (Fig. 255). The sheet uses recession and diagonal structure to organize space, and it modulates detail across buildings, boats, and figures with extraordinary assurance. Yet many passages are left open and spare. It lacks the saturated descriptive density of the *Young Hare* and the overt geometrical rigor of *St. Jerome*. By this stage, Dürer no longer needed to demonstrate control at every point. He had internalized his training.

He writes:

It is not my opinion that an artist has to measure his figures all the time. If thou hast learned the art of measurement and thus acquired theory and practice together... then it is not always necessary to measure everything all the time, for the acquired 'art' endows thee with a correct eye.

That phrase, "a correct eye," could stand as one of the central ambitions of this course. The goal of perspective, drawing, and repeated practice was not merely to follow rules forever, but to train perception so deeply that judgment became instinctive. Systems of seeing begin as external disciplines; at their highest level, they become second nature.

Dürer goes further:

The mind of artists is full of images which they might be able to produce; therefore, if a man properly using this art and naturally disposed therefore, were allowed to live many hundreds of years he would be capable – thanks to the power given to him by God – of pouring forth and producing every day new shapes of men and other creatures the like of which was never seen before nor thought of by any other man.

Drawing begins in observation and discipline, but it does not end there. Once theory and practice have been absorbed, the artist becomes capable of invention. These mature ideas appear with special clarity in *A Tuft of Cowslips*, painted just two years before Dürer's death. The work is modest in subject, but immense in achievement: a simple clump of wildflowers, seen with complete attentiveness and rendered with a freedom born of mastery.

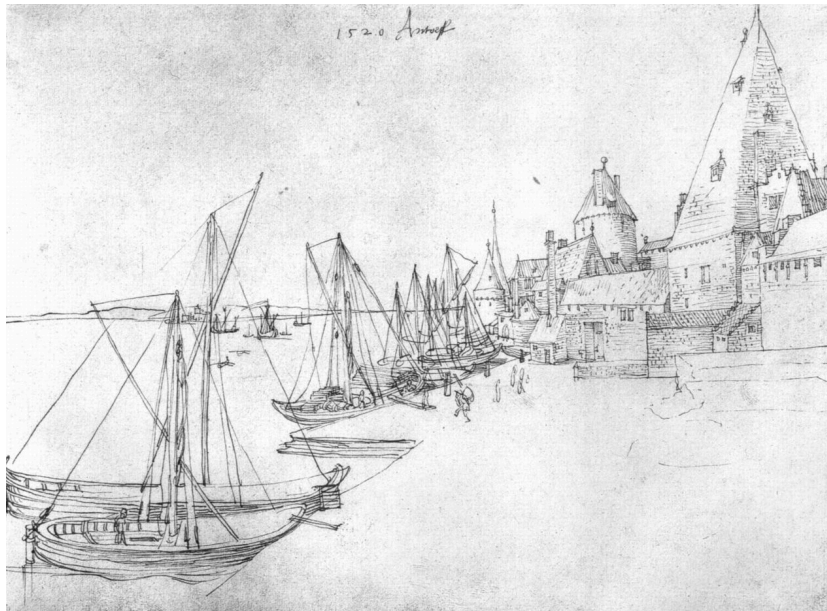


Figure 255: *View of Antwerp Harbor* by Dürer, pen and ink, 1520.

MANY MODERN ARTISTS use drawing not as a preparatory step, but as their primary medium. In their hands, drawing is no longer simply the hidden scaffolding beneath painting or sculpture. It becomes the finished form itself: large-scale, ambitious, and fully public.

Ethan Murrow is one such artist. He makes monumental drawings on paper in pencil and murals with paint-pencil, using line, shading, and scale to create immersive images that are at once precise and dreamlike. His work looks back to older traditions of representation even as it reworks them for the present. He is interested not only in what pictures show, but in how visual narratives are constructed and how images from the past continue to shape the stories artists tell.

Murrow has spoken of his admiration for the exquisite naturalistic detail of Jan van Eyck. That affinity matters in the context of this course. Van Eyck stood near the beginning of our story of heightened observation, microscopic attention, and the persuasive rendering of surfaces. Murrow returns to that legacy. His drawings borrow the authority of close observation, but they place it in strange, symbolic, and often unstable worlds.

In *Passage*, Murrow depicts himself in a boat beside a lamb, quoting the *Ghent Altarpiece*, also known as *The Adoration of the Mystic Lamb*. This act of quotation is important. Drawing brings art history into itself. A contemporary image is not made from sight alone, but also from memory, reference, and the reactivation of older visual forms. Murrow's work suggests that the history traced in this course—of perspective, observation, realism, and the making of convincing images—remains alive as material for invention.



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Figure 256: Images from the Expedia Mural Project (2019) and from *Hauling*, commissioned by the Currier Museum in 2018, by Ethan Murrow.

Figure 257: *Passage*, 2023, Ethan Murrow, graphite on paper, 48" × 48". By quoting the lamb of the *Ghent Altarpiece* within a contemporary graphite drawing, Murrow links modern draftsmanship to the longer history of naturalistic detail, symbolic form, and visual storytelling explored in this course.

GIDEON BOK draws the passage of time in enclosed spaces. Again and again, he returns to his own studio, depicting it in different states and at different moments. By introducing time into the act of drawing, he makes an ordinary room seem unstable, changing, and alive.

Much of the history of drawing and painting has aimed to fix the world in a single image: to organize space, capture appearances, and stabilize a point of view. Bok does something subtler. He shows that seeing is never entirely static, because places are shaped not only by geometry and light, but also by duration, repetition, memory, and use. His drawings remind us that a room is not just a container in space; it is a record of lived time.

Bok is attentive to the visible world, but what he makes visible is not merely furniture, walls, and objects. He reveals the temporal life of a space: the sense that a room changes as we inhabit it, return to it, and remember it.



TOBA KHEDOORI often depicts ordinary objects from unusual or shifting perspectives. By isolating them in sparse, unfamiliar settings, she creates a tension between naturalistic representation and abstraction. Her images are precise and painstakingly made by hand, yet they resist the stability and familiarity we often expect from realist depiction.

Artists can use drawing and perspective to make the world more coherent and convincing. Khedoori turns that history in a different direction. She has the discipline of close observation, but places objects in spaces that feel uncertain and estranged. The result is a kind of realism that makes the world newly strange.

Her work reminds us that drawing is not only a means of describing things accurately. Khedoori hovers between description and abstraction, extending drawing into a meditation on how objects appear to the eye.



PETER WAITE reimagines built structures by placing them into new visual frameworks. He makes large-scale drawings of recognizable sites—stadiums, gardens, bridges, museums, monuments, train stations, schools, prisons, casinos, and temples. These are places shaped by human intention and use, and they often carry strong social, emotional, or historical associations.

By translating such spaces into drawing, Waite asks us to see them differently. A place we think we know becomes newly strange when it is detached from ordinary experience and re-presented through line, scale, and framing. Perspective is not only a technical system for organizing space; it is also a way of shaping thought.

Waite's drawings do more than record architecture. They make us reconsider the structures we inhabit, admire, fear, or pass through without noticing. In his work, drawing becomes a way of shifting our relation to the built world, revealing familiar places from different points of view.



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Figure 258: *Waiting* c. 1882, by Edgar Degas, pastel on paper. Degas was an oil painter, but as he got older, he drifted toward drawing with pastels. Painting with oil grew tedious, and pastels gave him the strength of painting with the ease of drawing. [Getty Museum](#)